



d How about we begin with a brief overview of what F5 Networks does?

Mohan: F5 does a few things with applications. We make applications faster, smarter and safer. When it comes to running applications, whether it's running on your phone, laptop, cloud, etc., these are the three basic things you need. If the applications are not responsive then you're not going to use it. Smarter, in the sense that we make applications highly available. So when you click on an app, it immediately comes up without any delay. And we do that in different ways. The backend of a lot of apps run on different servers. Based on the location of the application, based on who you are and based on the time of the day, we can intelligently route the application through the best performing server.

Or we can intelligently route it through a more secure server based on who you are or where you are logging in from. If you are in a public place like Starbucks or in a high risk country, then we can add more checks before you get access.

And the same thing with safer. We focus on the applications here. We secure the application. For example, if there is a form within the app, we'll secure that. And that's just one aspect of it. We have protections that prevent malware attacks. Often, people click on something in a webpage or an app and it downloads a malware payload without them knowing. So we have applications

that can detect if it is a human or a bot. And we have DDoS protection as well. Especially in China, there are plenty of DDoS attacks happening within the country. Companies attack each other and it is very easy to do. And we see that happening in India with all the digitisation that's happening around. And then we perform SSL decryption. A lot of times, bad actors often encrypt malware which can prevent most security checks from detecting it. So we decrypt, check and then encrypt again.

d Coming to the security aspect. If I were to be in a high-risk country with unsecure networks, how would your system work?

Mohan: We have a dynamic system for the security aspect. So if you were in a high risk area, I can deny you access. It's completely up to the company policy. Perhaps, I can give you access to, let's say, marketing resources but I'll deny you access to the financial backend. I can put priorities on the applications that you are accessing. So internal engineering documents and other critical resources will be blocked unless you are within your company premises. Even if you were to use a rooted phone and spoof your identity, you'd still have tokens and extra challenges to tackle before getting access. It's always a constant battle between IT and security. Security and convenience don't go together.

d As you add more layers of tech/software, don't you think that there are more avenues for attack vectors to compromise the overall system?

Mohan: Security agencies and bad actors are always in a cat and mouse game. Enterprises are quite well protected but the man on the street is often not so well aware. And bad actors always tend to go for the weakest link in the chain. And most of the times, the ball's in the user's court. So we need to perform a bit of digital hygiene. So you need to update your software, change passwords on a regular basis and backup your data. We can certainly depend on technology a lot but we need to do our own bit.

d Can the government play a role in averting mass infection?

Mohan: The government agencies can definitely play a role. Security is like insurance. I'm here like an insurance salesman. It's only after you suffer an accident that you think of taking insurance. And that's when you end up paying more. If the government has mandatory requirements for certain key industries, then that will help. Companies are like you and me. We'll only get insurance when we're made to get it. If there are regulatory bodies that work with industries like banking, power, telecom, etc., to provide a minimum security framework, then that'll make things better. **d**